timeless themes of building the republic as it does on public economics. In India, the modernization of the political system and the economy is taking place at the same time—and feeding into each other. In this process, economic policy strategy must serve the larger objective of building the republic. The foundations of liberal democracy—the principles of debate, dispersion of power, the rule of law and curtailing executive discretion—are integral to solving the difficulties of economic policy that afflict India today.

There is science in a core of economics and politics. These are the areas where the analytical foundations and empirical evidence are strong. And then, beyond that, there is a large class of questions where we have opinions and insights, but the scientific foundations are lacking. This is where the policy thinkers and practitioners have to form judgements in each situation that may diverge from each other, and feel their way into the world through intuition and experience. This is the art of public policy. We take on the left-brain and the right-brain aspects.

We care about the ideas and we care about translating them into action. Some parts of the book are more analytical and conceptual, while others are more practical and directly link to action.

When the rubber hits the road, there are tangible policy questions in each area, such as oil exploration or inflation targeting. There are many fascinating areas of work in progress, all across the Indian landscape, where there is the ‘slow boring of hard boards’ of policy reform. While we draw on examples from many domains, this is not a handbook of policy papers. We offer general insights that are valuable across diverse fields.

We live in an age of social media. The degradation of norms of discourse and the lowering of technical bars in the policy discourse have harmed the ability of liberal democracies to find politically stable compromises. Our attempt in this book is to help recover common ground, to find a shared intellectual framework and vocabulary that a lot of us may be able to agree upon. Towards this objective, we have stuck to what we hope is the relatively non-controversial terrain. This has involved downplaying issues of ethical preferences and income redistribution.